

Trust Over Templates: OUF's Secret Sauce for Defying the Humanitarian Industrial Complex

by Shantara Pintak

This article is a synthesization of the author's Master's thesis titled, "Epistemological Disenfranchisement in the Humanitarian Sector: How Global North Metrics Marginalize Indigenous Knowledge Management".

"Perhaps the most important task of all would be to undertake studies in contemporary alternatives to Orientalism, to ask how one can study other cultures and peoples from a libertarian, or a nonrepressive and nonmanipulative, perspective. But then one would have to rethink the whole complex problem of knowledge and power." — Dr. Edward W. Said¹

At the recent [2026 World Decolonization Forum](#) session "[The Problem of Knowledge Production: Decolonizing Methodologies](#)", Dr. Syed Farid Alatas noted the "global neoliberal system" as being "obsessed with metrics".² This obsession is a fundamental aspect of the way knowledge is produced and valued in the humanitarian sector. Dr. Walter Mignolo proclaimed, "What modernity hides is coloniality... the logic of domination, of appropriation, of exploitation—of diminishing your language and your knowledge and your beliefs".³

These statements identify the power dynamics that are embedded in the very structure of international institutions, like those that fund, manage, and shape the humanitarian sector. The operational structure of management and funding reliant on such power imbalance still shapes the sector, where "the natives existed more vividly in Geneva, where all this information was gathered and processed, than they did in the mandate territories themselves."⁴

"The imposition of bureaucracy by donors and INGOs in order to protect people and whole organizations along the value chain of civil society has come to supplant the idea of meaningful engagement", stated Diane Doane, author of [The INGO Problem: Power, Privilege, and](#)

¹ Edward W. Said, *Orientalism* (London and Henley: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1978), 35.

² World Decolonization Forum, *Disentangling Colonial Codes from the Circulation of Knowledge* (Istanbul: World Decolonization Forum, 2026).

³ Ibid.

⁴ Antony Anghie, *Imperialism, Sovereignty, and the Making of International Law* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005), 184, <https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511614262>.

[Renewal](#).⁵ In a field where time and effort directly correspond to life and death, “the problems of bureaucracy and how it takes their time away from helping people, the ridiculous amounts of form-filling and meetings” simply undermines real-world impact.⁶

In his article “Goal-Coded Systems and the Crisis of Orientation”, professor Indy Johar, co-founder of Dark Matter Labs, identifies the nuances that differentiate agency from orientation. Although Johar writes with a focus on Artificial Intelligence, his insights are applicable to the humanitarian sector and its systems of standardization. Johar argues that “goal-coded systems”—systems that are designed to achieve specific goals—can lead to a “crisis of orientation” for the users through the emphasis and “tyranny of targets”.⁷ In this case, the users being humanitarian workers in the Global South who are required to navigate these systems. The “goal-coded systems” and “their operative purpose arrives from outside. They are prompted, instructed, rewarded, benchmarked, fine-tuned, evaluated, constrained, deployed and corrected by external frames”.⁸ The external frame, here, being the donor institutions and the wider humanitarian system that is structured around the requirements and expectations of these donors.

Moses Isooba of the Uganda National NGO Forum explained, “Ultimately, all of our change in shifting power is about relationships and language is how we communicate in a relationship. We ring-fence people who get paid in development by using a coded language. We don’t want the other people to speak. We speak in acronyms, frameworks, but they’re veils, they mask the real human beings like you and me, and if we can change the language, we can build better relationships”.⁹

Many critics of the sector have pointed to this structure as a key flaw of the “Humanitarian Industrial Complex”, to use the terminology of Mr. Mohammad Saeed Rahman, founder of the One Ummah Foundation (OUF).¹⁰ Studies have found that these “fund-meritaries” actually cost more than giving directly to community-based organizations.¹¹ The overspending is precisely

⁵ Deborah Doane, *The INGO Problem: Power, Privilege, and Renewal* (Rugby, UK: Practical Action Publishing, 2024), 42–43, <https://doi.org/10.3362/9781788534420>.

⁶ Ibid., 18.

⁷ Indy Johar, “Goal-Coded Systems and the Crisis of Orientation,” Indy Johar (Substack), May 2, 2026, <https://indyjohar.substack.com/p/goal-coded-systems-and-the-crisis>.

⁸ Ibid.

⁹ Ibid., 72.

¹⁰ Mohammad Saeed Rahman, interview by Shantara Pintak, April 25, 2026.

¹¹ Doane, *INGO Problem*, 61.

due to the “inflated international overhead and salary costs”¹² that Mr. Rahman called out. In fact, direct funding to local intermediaries and organizations “can deliver programming that is 32% more cost efficient than [through] international intermediaries”.¹³ The One Ummah Foundation has proven this to be true, with only 1 per cent spent on management and administrative costs, 1 per cent on fundraising efforts, and 98 per cent dedicated to actual humanitarian aid programs.

INGO giants have a vested interest in maintaining their cut of the pie justified through narratives around trust, accountability, and transparency. There is an assumed mistrust of local organizations, which is used to justify the need for INGOs to act as intermediaries and gatekeepers of knowledge production and finances. What results is paternalism fueled by a legacy of colonial power dynamics. Evaluation in global development centers on the White subject as the doer, the Savior and the neutral expert. While couched in the discourse of ‘accountability’ and ‘evidence-based’ decision making, evaluation implicitly serves as a tool for White surveillance.

“Unfortunately, the assessment of who has ‘capacity’ has been weaponized and used as means to justify the slow relinquishment of power by INGOs and their hollow promises of localization. We require more individuals actively engaged in community work and fewer confined to their desks, endlessly reporting to donors.”¹⁴ — Michael Vincent Mercado, Voice and Insights Lab Team Manager at the Center for Disaster Preparedness Foundation

The “western-derived”, ill defined notion of ‘capacity’—a trait humanitarians from the Global South are assumed to lack—lays the foundation for paternalism through intervention and oversight by Global North institutions.¹⁵ According to Doane, “most risk management and due diligence systems” of these institutions are concerned with capacity.¹⁶

Donors hype vague concepts of ‘empowerment’ and ‘localization,’ but the extent of autonomy granted to local ‘partner’ organizations and their staff is limited by the standardized reporting

¹² Ibid.

¹³ Ibid.

¹⁴ Ibid., 50.

¹⁵ Ibid.

¹⁶ Ibid.

mechanisms. Looking back to Johar's thoughts on "goal-coded systems", he argues that orientation is often overlooked:

"Orientation is deeper than agency. Orientation is the formation of concern. It is the emergence of direction from within a life, a body, a history, a field of relations, a condition of vulnerability, a horizon of death and continuity. Orientation is not merely the capacity to pursue an end. It is the capacity to discover, revise and be claimed by what ends are worth pursuing."¹⁷

Without genuine orientation, individuals become "custodians of comprehension" rather than "catalysts for transformation".¹⁸ In the humanitarian sector, this can manifest in the way that local humanitarian workers must prioritize satisfying donor requirements. These humanitarians have to spend their time filling out forms and writing reports that are designed to meet the expectations of donors rather than interacting with the communities they come from and serve.

Mr. Rahman explained the philosophy of One Ummah Foundation that has resulted in direct funding to local humanitarian organizations across more than 70 countries: "We don't want to know how the watch was invented... sophistication means simplicity not complexity."¹⁹ Rather than layering on multi-indicator frameworks based on mistrust, this funder builds accountability through sustained relationships with local organizations, treating trust as the mechanism of 'oversight' rather than paperwork.²⁰ This is One Ummah Foundation's "secret sauce"²¹ that defies the overlords of the Humanitarian Industrial Complex. The contrast is instructive: the reporting burden is not an inevitable feature of responsible funding—it is a design choice based on neocolonial power dynamics.

Mr. Rahman explained that the One Ummah Foundation bases their funding structure with greater emphasis on refusing to "reinvent the wheel" or "push down" reporting requirements onto local partners.²² Instead, they rely on relationship-building to vet local practitioners who then provide receipts and "progress reports on a volunteer basis" rather than as a mandated,

¹⁷ Johar, "Goal-Coded Systems and the Crisis of Orientation."

¹⁸ Indy Johar, "The Black Hole Gravity of Knowledge and Knowing," Indy Johar (Substack), October 21, 2025, <https://indyjohar.substack.com/p/the-black-hole-gravity-of-knowledge>.

¹⁹ Rahman, interview.

²⁰ Ibid.

²¹ Ibid.

²² Ibid.

rigid exercise.²³ This approach is intentional: by resisting the imposition of Western bureaucratic norms, the founder seeks to preserve the “real richness” of local culture.²⁴ By identifying existing organizations to offer direct funding, the foundation aims to “enhance what they [the local organization] are doing and become more like a catalyst” by supporting the ways in which they are already working.²⁵

“We do not want to ever change their value system, their culture, because that’s where the real richness comes from. We believe in absolute pluralism... We don’t go through bureaucracy and make it difficult for people.”²⁶ – Mr. Rahman

This Catalyst Approach is an operational and relational approach for reform founded on Sankofaism: a philosophical paradigm that focuses on promoting African and indigenous ways of knowledge and skill development.²⁷ Sankofaism emphasises building bridges between the past and present to offer a formidable future.²⁸ The Catalyst Approach provides the structural space required for Sankofaism to flourish, without imposing any one cultural norm, in promotion of enfranchisement of local humanitarian practitioners.

Where mainstream donors extract local organizations into the logic of the Humanitarian Industrial Complex through bureaucratic burdens, this model is an approach for project design to be built from the ground up by the actual humanitarians in and from the contexts in question, the ones the One Ummah Foundation recognizes as having “skin in the game”.²⁹ The goal is not replacement but withdrawal: creating the structural conditions for local knowledge systems to re-emerge on their own terms.

²³ Ibid.

²⁴ Ibid.

²⁵ Ibid.

²⁶ Ibid.

²⁷ Tsetselelane D. Mdhluli et al., "Knowledge Management: Preserving, Managing and Sharing Indigenous Knowledge through Digital Library," *HTS Teologiese Studies / Theological Studies* 77, no. 2 (2021): 3, <https://doi.org/10.4102/hts.v77i2.6795>.

²⁸ Ibid

²⁹ Rahman, interview.

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